

Spacecraft Attitude Determination and Control Technical Report

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Change Log

Homework	Date	Description of Changes
1	02-27-2026	Described mission description, requirements and spacecraft model. Calculated COM, body inertia, principle axes, surface normal vectors and surface areas of the spacecraft. Simulated spacecraft orbital dynamics and Euler's equation. Provided a stability analysis about each principle axis with plots on the momentum sphere.
2	03-13-2026	Designed a stable spin configuration that keeps the solar panels pointing toward the sun using super spin and dynamic balance. Added gyrostat dynamics to the simulation and described attitude sensors. Simulated noisy measurements from each attitude sensor and used these simulated measurements for static attitude determination.
3	04-07-2026	Fixed dynamic balance bug (was not renormalizing the quaternion in the attitude dynamics sim). Organized the code base. Implement sensor models and a recursive attitude estimator.

Github Repository: <https://github.com/vegaf1/acds-mit-course>

Homework 1

Mission Description and Requirements

This report analyzes the Starling mission. It consists of four 6-unit CubeSats flying in a sun synchronous circular orbit at an altitude of 550 km. The high-level mission objectives consist of swarm maneuver planning and execution, relative navigation, and autonomous coordination between the spacecraft [1]. Onboard the satellites, there are two commercial star-trackers, dual-band GPS receivers, reaction wheels, a Globalstar beacon radio, and an S-band radio [2]. The actuation includes a cold gas propulsion system called Hamlet providing up to 30 m/s of delta-V for maneuvers [3]. The satellite is a Blue Canyon XB 6U cubesat which has a the pointing accuracy of ± 0.002 degrees, slew rate of 360 degrees per minute, and pointing stability of 1 arcsecond over 1 second [4].

Spacecraft Model

Part 1: We assume the dimensions of the 6U cubesat are 20 cm x 10 cm x 34 cm. Another assumption is the size of the panels are 30 cm x 100 cm (thickness not taken into account). The body axes are defined in Figure 1. The origin is defined to be the center of the spacecraft bus.

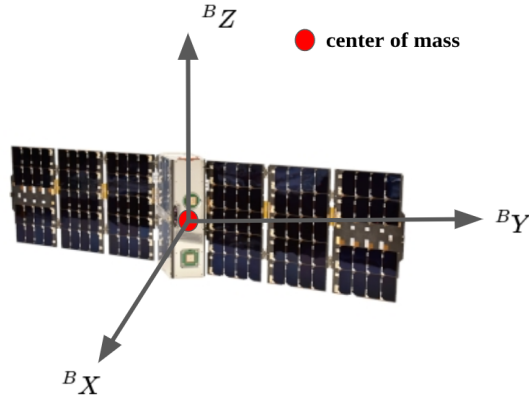
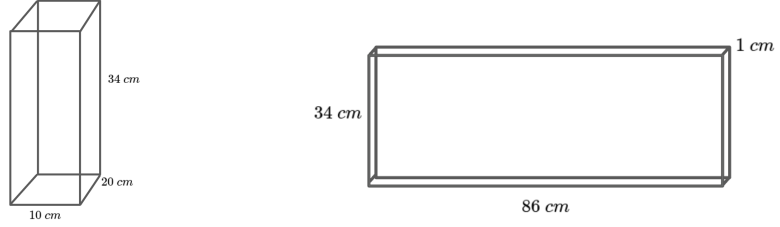


Figure 1: Body axes definition for Starling mission spacecraft

Part 2: We model the spacecraft as 3 rectangular prisms. One larger rectangular prism for the spacecraft body and another 2 thin rectangular prisms representing the solar panels. This decomposition along with the dimensions of each rectangular prism are depicted in Figure 2. To find the center of mass, we apply Equation 1, where m_k is the mass of each of the rectangular prisms and x_k is the distance from the body frame origin to the center of mass of each



(a) Starling bus rectangle decomposition and dimensions (b) Starling solar panels rectangular decomposition and dimensions

Figure 2: Starling 6U Cubesat Rectangular Decomposition and Dimensions

rectangular prism. We assume the mass of the satellite bus m_1 is 12 kg, the mass of each solar panel (m_2, m_3) is 1 kg. Another assumption is that the solar panels are at 45 degrees from the body X-axis and Y-axis.

$$X_{com} = \frac{\sum_{k=1}^n m_k x_k}{\sum_{k=1}^n m_k} \quad (1)$$

COM Calculation

$m_1 = 12 \text{ kg}$, $r_1 = (0, 0, 0) \text{ cm}$

$m_2 = 1 \text{ kg}$, $r_2 = (35.36, 35.36, 0) \text{ cm}$

$m_3 = 1 \text{ kg}$, $r_3 = (-35.36, -35.36, 0) \text{ cm}$

$r_{\text{com}} = [0, 0, 0] \text{ cm}$

This makes sense spacecraft because the spacecraft is symmetric.

To calculate the body-frame moment of inertia, we need to combine the individual inertias of each rectangular prism. We do this by adding the inertias of each individual term and adding the point-mass terms about the combined centered of mass (Equation 2).

$$J_{\text{combined}} = J_1 + J_2 + J_3 + m_1(r_1^T r_1 I - r_1 r_1^T) + m_2(r_2^T r_2 I - r_2 r_2^T) + m_3(r_3^T r_3 I - r_3 r_3^T) \quad (2)$$

In this equation, the term r_k is the distance from each rectangular prism center of mass to the center of mass of the spacecraft. Since the COM of the spacecraft is the origin of the body frame, the r terms remain the same from

the previous part. ${}^B J = \begin{bmatrix} 5915.99 & -2500.66 & 0.0 \\ -2500.66 & 3949.49 & 0.0 \\ 0.0 & 0.0 & 7168.15 \end{bmatrix} \text{ kg} \cdot \text{cm}^2$

Part 3: The principle axes of a spacecraft is the basis where the body frame moment of inertia is diagonal. We calculate by taking an eigen decomposition of the body frame moment of inertia. The set of eigenvectors becomes the principle axes P .

$$P = \begin{bmatrix} 0.56306 & 0.0 & 0.826416 \\ 0.826416 & 0.0 & -0.56306 \\ 0.0 & 1.0 & 0.0 \end{bmatrix}$$

The rotation between the principle frame and body frame is defined by matrix P . To transform the body frame inertia into the principle frame inertia, we apply the following: ${}^P J = P^T {}^B J P$.

Part 4: We can discretize the satellite bus into 6 faces, and the solar panels into 5 faces each. This is a total of 16 faces to represent the spacecraft. The next section* will specify the centroid, normal vector, and area of each piece.

Spacecraft bus:

Face 1:

Centroid: $[0, 5, 0] \text{ cm}$

Normal Vector: $[0, 1, 0]$

Area: 680 cm^2

Face 2:

Centroid: $[0, -5, 0] \text{ cm}$

Normal Vector: $[0, -1, 0]$

Area: 680 cm^2

Face 3:

Centroid: $[10, 0, 0] \text{ cm}$

Normal Vector: $[1, 0, 0]$

Area: 340 cm^2

Face 4:

Centroid: $[-10, 0, 0]$ cm

Normal Vector: $[-1, 0, 0]$

Area: 340 cm^2

Face 5:

Centroid: $[0, 0, 17]$ cm

Normal Vector: $[0, 0, 1]$

Area: 200 cm^2

Face 6:

Centroid: $[0, 0, -17]$ cm

Normal Vector: $[0, 0, -1]$

Area: 200 cm^2

Solar Panel 1:

Face 1:

Centroid: $[35.36, 35.36, 0]$ cm

Normal Vector: $[-\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, 0]$

Area: 2924 cm^2

Face 2:

Centroid: $[35.36, 35.36, 0]$ cm

Normal Vector: $[\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, -\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, 0]$

Area: 2924 cm^2

Face 3:

Centroid: $[35.36, 35.36, 17.0]$

Normal Vector: $[0, 0, 1]$

Area: 86 cm^2

Face 4:

Centroid: $[35.36, 35.36, -17.0]$

Normal Vector: $[0, 0, -1]$

Area: 86 cm^2

Face 5:

Centroid: $[70.71, 70.71, 0.0]$

Normal Vector: $[\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, 0]$

Area: 86 cm^2

Solar Panel 2:

Face 1:

Centroid: $[-35.36, -35.36, 0]$ cm

Normal Vector: $[-\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, \frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, 0]$

Area: 2924 cm^2

Face 2:

Centroid: $[-35.36, -35.36, 0]$ cm

Normal Vector: $[\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, -\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, 0]$

Area: 2924 cm^2

Face 3:

Centroid: $[-35.36, -35.36, 17.0]$

Normal Vector: $[0, 0, 1]$

Area: 86 cm^2

Face 4:

Centroid: [-35.36, -35.36, -17.0]

Normal Vector: [0, 0, -1]

Area: 86 cm²**Face 5:**

Centroid: [-70.71, -70.71, 0.0]

Normal Vector: $[-\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, -\frac{\sqrt{2}}{2}, 0]$ Area: 86 cm²

Dynamics

Equation 3 calculates the gravitational acceleration, and Equation 4 calculates the J2 acceleration. The variable r is the position and v is the velocity. For now, we assume that the total acceleration is the sum of both of these accelerations.

$$a_g = \frac{-\mu}{||r||^3} r \quad (3)$$

$$a_{J_2} = -\frac{3}{2} \frac{J_2 \mu R_E^2}{r^5} \begin{bmatrix} \left(1 - 5 \left(\frac{x_3}{r}\right)^2\right) x_1 \\ \left(1 - 5 \left(\frac{x_3}{r}\right)^2\right) x_2 \\ \left(3 - 5 \left(\frac{x_3}{r}\right)^2\right) x_3 \end{bmatrix} \quad (4)$$

$$a_{\text{total}} = a_g + a_{J_2} \quad (5)$$

We implemented an RK4 integrator and simulated the dynamics for 10 revolutions. The resulting trajectory is in Figure 3.

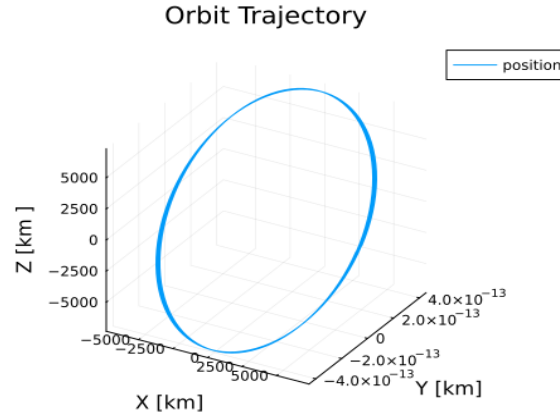


Figure 3: Orbit Trajectory

Euler's Equation

Part 1: The ODE's for Euler's equation along the principle axes are in Equation 6.

$$\begin{aligned} {}^P J_{11} {}^P \dot{\omega}_1 + ({}^P J_{33} - {}^P J_{22}) {}^P \omega_2 {}^P \omega_3 &= {}^P \tau_1 \\ {}^P J_{22} {}^P \dot{\omega}_2 + ({}^P J_{11} - {}^P J_{33}) {}^P \omega_1 {}^P \omega_3 &= {}^P \tau_2 \\ {}^P J_{33} {}^P \dot{\omega}_3 + ({}^P J_{22} - {}^P J_{11}) {}^P \omega_1 {}^P \omega_2 &= {}^P \tau_3 \end{aligned} \quad (6)$$

Part 2: The initial condition simulated had a magnitude of 10 RPM. The perturbation had a magnitude of $0.1 \frac{\text{rad}}{\text{s}}$ and the direction was sampled from a normal distribution. Figure 4 shows a spin around the minor axis that is marginally stable. There is nutation around the y and z axes of the principle frame. Figure 6 shows a spin around the major axis that is also marginally stable. There is nutation around the x and z principle axes. Finally, Figure 5 shows an unstable spin around the intermediate axis. We can observe the switching behavior that occurs in the x and y-directions of the angular velocity from positive to negative.

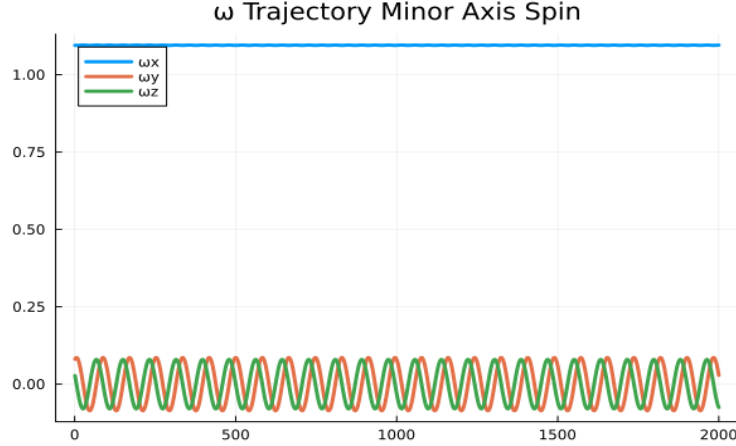


Figure 4: Minor Axis Spin Angular Velocity Trajectory

Part 3: Figures 7 and 8 show a plot of the momentum sphere with the equilibrium points. The green markers indicate the stable equilibrium points (minor/major axis) and the red markers are the unstable equilibria (intermediate axis).

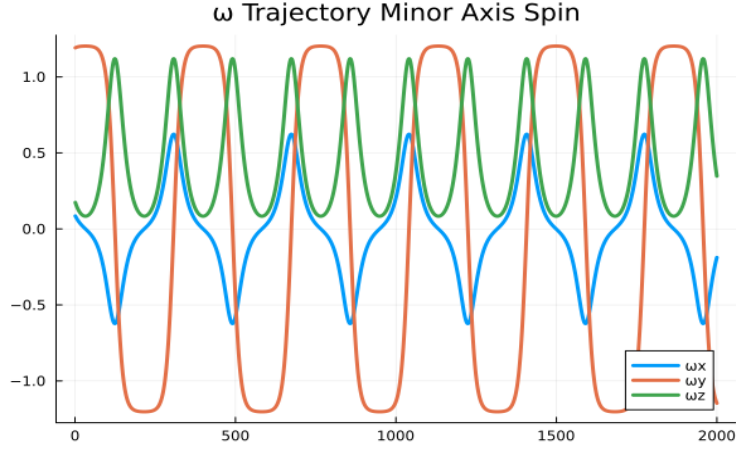


Figure 5: Intermediate Axis Spin Angular Velocity Trajectory

Next, we show several momentum trajectories on the momentum sphere from spinning about each of the principle axes. The momentum trajectories are depicted by the blue lines while the equilibrium points are represented by markers. The red marker indicates unstable equilibria (along the intermediate axis), while green are the stable equilibria. For the intermediate axis, the initial condition has a magnitude of 20 RPM with a perturbation in a random direction with a magnitude of $0.1 \frac{rad}{s}$. The momentum trajectory about the intermediate axis is shown in Figure 9. It shows the same switching behavior we observed from the angular velocity plot in Figure 5

Next, we simulated a spin about the minor axis. The initial angular velocity is set to a magnitude of 3 RPM with a disturbance in a random direction with a magnitude of $0.1 \frac{rad}{s}$. The momentum trajectory about the minor axis is shown in Figure 10. This is a stable equilibria, therefore the momentum trajectory is a periodic orbit about the equilibrium point.

Lastly, we simulated a spin about the major axis with an initial angular velocity magnitude set to 3 RPM with an additive random disturbance with a magnitude of $0.1 \frac{rad}{s}$. This is also a stable equilibria; therefore, the result is a periodic orbit about the equilibrium point.

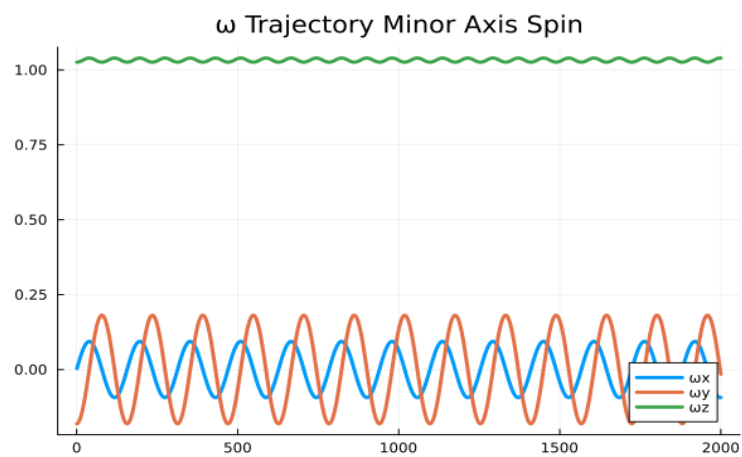


Figure 6: Major Axis Spin Angular Velocity Trajectory

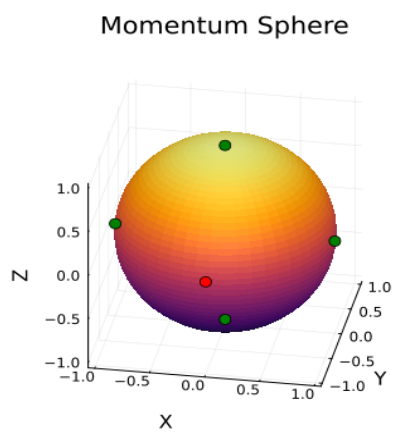


Figure 7: Momentum Sphere View 1

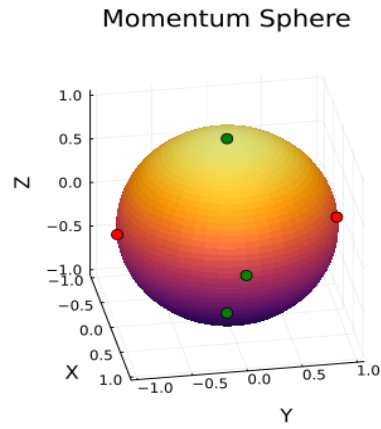


Figure 8: Momentum Sphere View 2

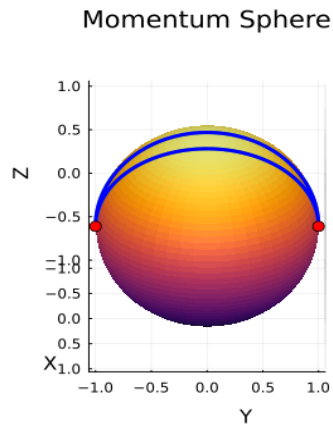


Figure 9: Momentum Trajectory about the Intermediate Axis

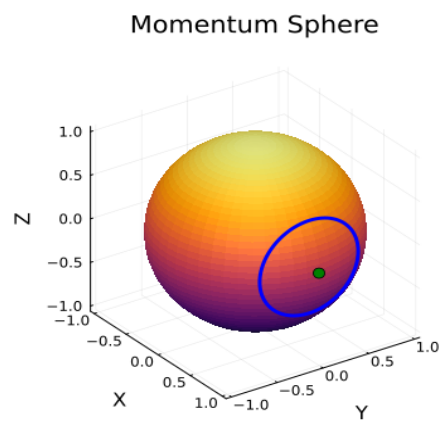


Figure 10: Momentum Trajectory about the Minor Axis

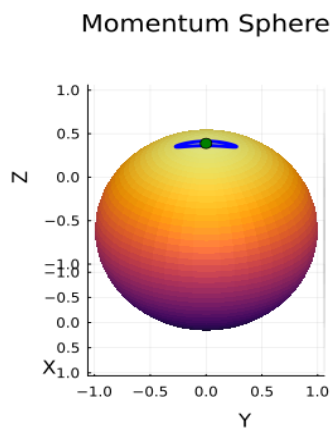


Figure 11: Momentum Trajectory about the Major Axis

Homework 2

Safe Mode

1. To ensure the solar panel normal vector is not parallel to a principle axis, we randomly perturb the body inertia matrix. This is done by taking an eigen-decomposition, perturbing the diagonal vector containing the eigenvalues, and reconstructing the body inertia matrix using the perturbed eigenvalue matrix.
2. To find the desired angular velocity vector in the body frame corresponding to a spin of 10 RPM about the solar panel vector we multiply the magnitude by the direction of the solar panel normal in the body frame. ${}^B\omega = ||\omega||^B n$

$${}^B\omega = \begin{bmatrix} -7.07 \\ 7.07 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix} \text{ rad/s}$$

3. Dynamic balance allows us to spin a spacecraft along a non-principle axis and superspin allows the spacecraft obtain a marginally stable spin by changing it's major axis by adding a rotor momentum to set an effective inertia greater than the major axis inertia by some margin. Using dynamic balance and superspin, we are able to stabilize to spin the satellite about the angular velocity vector in the direction of the solar panel normal. For dynamic balance, $\dot{\omega} = 0$, therefore from the gyrostat equation, we define the no wobble condition as the following

$$\omega \times (J\omega + \rho) = 0 \quad (7)$$

To obtain a unique solution, we also define along with the super spin condition $\rho^T \omega = \rho_s \omega_s$ to get a unique solution. The values ($\omega_s = ||\omega||$ and ρ_s are obtained from the superspin condition $\rho_s \geq \omega_s(J_{33} - J_s)$). We choose J_{33} here because it is the minimum-energy state. The term J_s is the inertia in the desired spin axis frame $J_s = (\frac{\omega}{\omega_s})^T J (\frac{\omega}{\omega_s})$.

4. The gyrostat equation is

$$J^B \omega + {}^B \dot{\rho} + {}^B \omega \times (J^B \omega + \rho) = {}^B \tau \quad (8)$$

where J is the inertia in the body frame, ${}^B\omega$ is the angular velocity in the body frame, ρ is the rotor momentum, and $\dot{\rho}$ is the rotor momentum rate.

5. The perturbation on the initial state has a magnitude of $0.1 \frac{\text{rad}}{\text{s}}$ and sampled from a normal distribution. The result of the simulation is stable about the solar panel normal vector as shown in Figure 12.

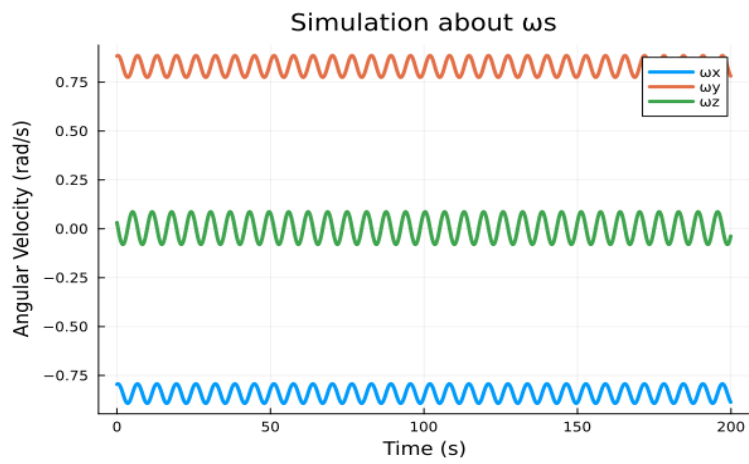


Figure 12: Angular velocity simulation about the solar panel normal vector

Spacecraft Dynamics

Figure 13 shows the attitude quaternion components for a stable spin about the solar panel normal vector. The simulation rate is set to 10 Hz and the horizon is set to approximately 3 minutes (2000 timesteps). Figure 14 shows the pointing error in degrees from the solar panel normal vector and the sun vector that is assumed to be at $[1,0,0]$ in ECI.

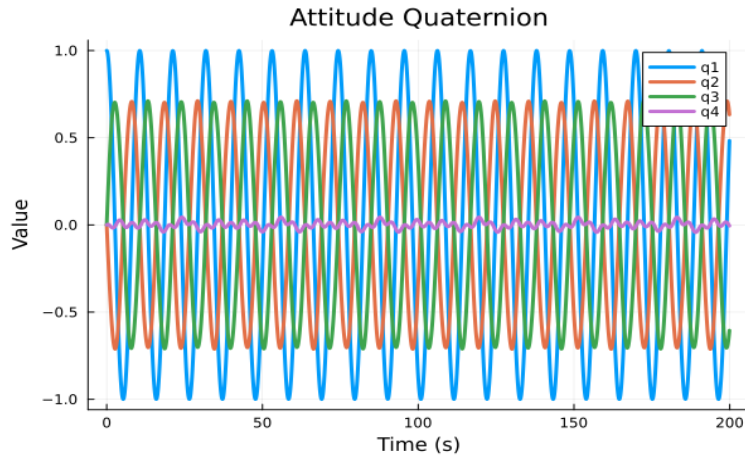


Figure 13: Components of the Attitude Quaternion

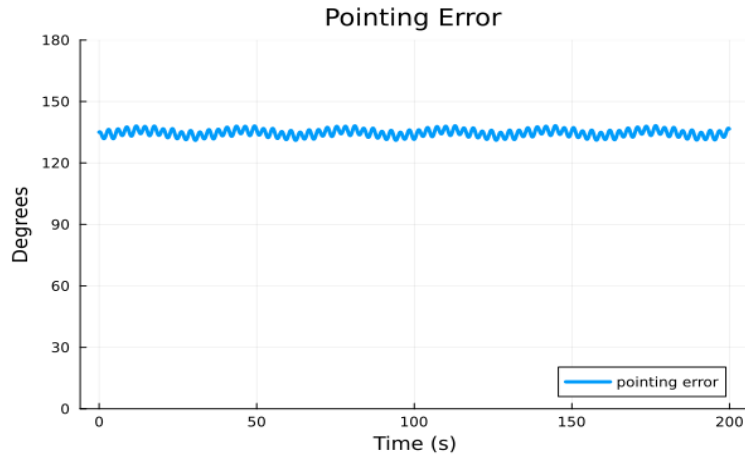


Figure 14: Pointing Error with the sun vector

Attitude Sensors

The attitude sensors onboard the spacecraft are two commercial star trackers. The reported pointing accuracy is ± 0.002 degrees as the $1\text{-}\sigma$ standard deviation [1]. From this specification we must convert the angular metric into an uncertainty on a bearing vector. We define a bearing measurement at time i as b_i . The covariance is dependent on the direction of the bearing measurement, as the uncertainty will be in the orthogonal subspace to b_i . To do this, we can use the projection $(I - b_i b_i^T)$ and multiply it by our variance converted into radians (this is valid for small angles, which is the case for this sensor). The equation for the covariance matrices is

$$P_s = \sigma^2(I - b_i b_i^T) \quad (9)$$

We can then sample a noisy measurement b_n by

$$b_n = b_i + \sqrt{P_s}d \quad (10)$$

where d is a 3 dimensional vector sampled from a normal distribution. To verify that the error statistics are consistent, we can take the arc cosine of the dot product between the normal body measurement and the true body measurement. This operation gives us the angle difference between both vectors and most should fall within the 1-sigma range. As seen in Figure 15 the average angle difference is close to the 0.002 deg metric from the star tracker specification sheet.

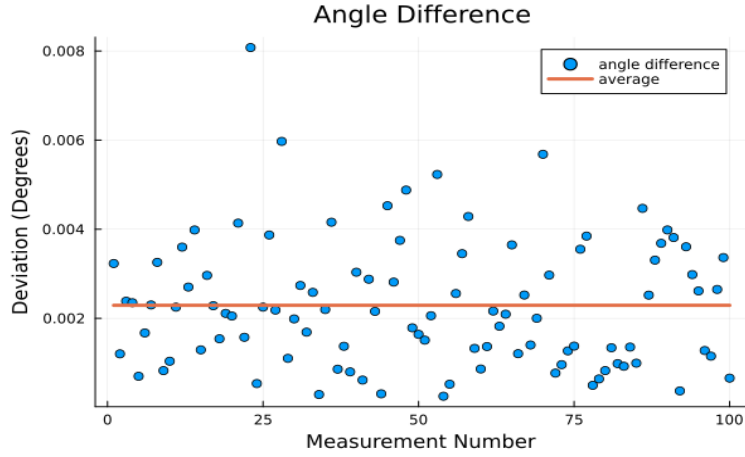


Figure 15: Angle difference between the noisy measurements and true measurements in the body frame

Static Attitude Estimation

For 100 measurements, we ran a MonteCarlo simulation of both the SDP and SVD method of solving Wabha's problem. The rotation error in degrees are very similar and shown in Figures 16 and 17. Using BenchmarkTools.jl in Julia, we are also able to obtain an average time for each approach to run. The average time for the SDP method was 0.00184 seconds while the SVD solution ran in 7.007×10^{-6} seconds.

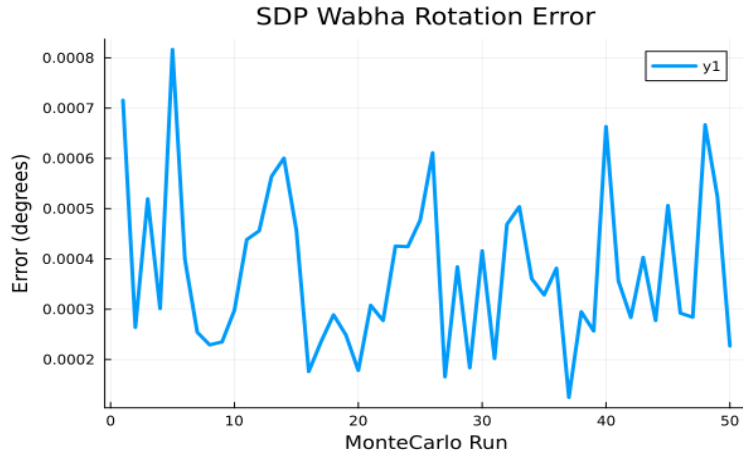


Figure 16: Rotation Error in degrees from solving Wabha's problem using an SDP

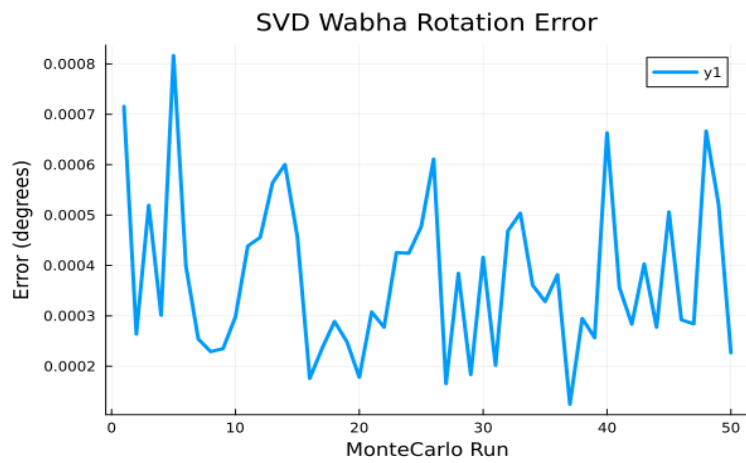


Figure 17: Rotation Error in degrees from solving Wabha's problem using an SVD

Homework 3

Attitude Sensors

Recursive Attitude Estimation

References

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- [2] S. Miller, C. Adams, N. Alem, H. Cannon, R. Grashuis, T. Hendriks, S. Hwang, M. Iatauro, C. Pires, J. Kruger *et al.*, “Smallsat 2024-starling cubesat swarm technology demonstration flight results,” in *Proceedings of the 38th Annual Small Satellite Conference*, no. SSC24-I-06. Small Satellite Conference, 2024.
- [3] T. Stevenson, “Flight results and lessons learned from the starling propulsion system,” 2024.
- [4] NASA RSDO, “Rapid IV Catalog: BCT CubeSat Marketing Sheet (v6).”